

Aquifer Open Study Notes

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Zechariah 1:1

This superscription, or introductory statement, classifies the book of Zechariah as an *oracle*, an authoritative message inspired by God. The prophet Zechariah was God's emissary, designated to speak with God's authority. • King Darius's reign (521–486 BC) was in the early years of the Persian Empire (539–331 BC).

Zechariah 1:1–6

The prelude identifies the book's themes as repentance and spiritual renewal, and establishes a tone of hope and encouragement.

Zechariah 1:3

the Lord of Heaven's Armies: God has an infinite number of angelic troops ready to carry out his will (see [2 Kgs 6:17](#); [Matt 26:53](#)). The phrase was probably meant to be an encouragement to the Judeans. • Return to me: A person who repents makes a complete turnaround—a shift away from sin and self toward loyalty to God and his covenant (see [Isa 44:22](#); [Mal 3:7](#); see also [Pss 80:3–14](#); [85:4–8](#)).

Zechariah 1:4

Before the Exile, earlier prophets actively called Judah and Israel to repentance. Zechariah especially reflects the prophetic influence of Jeremiah and Ezekiel. • ancestors who would not listen: The people of Israel ([2 Kgs 17:13–14](#)) and Judah ([2 Chr 36:15–16](#)) were taken into exile because they stubbornly refused to heed the word of the Lord (cp. [2 Chr 30:7](#)).

Zechariah 1:6

everything . . . happened: The covenant curses ([Deut 28:15–68](#)) had overtaken their ancestors who refused to obey God.

Zechariah 1:7–17

Zechariah's first vision depicts God's concern for Jerusalem ([1:7–15](#)), followed by a response ([1:16–17](#)) that confirmed God's intentions to rebuild his Temple and restore the city's prosperity.

Zechariah 1:7–6.15

These eight visions addressed the Judeans' fears that prevented them from responding in faith to God's promises. These visions, which occurred two months after Haggai's final two messages ([Hag 2:10–19](#), [20–23](#)), suggest that Haggai's prophecies were being fulfilled.

Zechariah 1:8

The vision during the night follows a standard pattern: an introductory statement, a description of the vision, the prophet's request for an interpretation, and an angelic explanation. • The myrtle trees were probably in the wooded Kidron valley outside of Jerusalem. The Lord had symbolically returned to the city's outskirts but had not yet entered Jerusalem because the Temple was still under construction. • The colors of the red, brown, and white horses are not significant to this vision's meaning. These angelic riders patrolled the earth ([1:10](#)), showing God's continuing concern over Jerusalem.

Zechariah 1:10

Patrol suggests the angelic riders' ongoing scrutiny of the earth.

Zechariah 1:11

The man sitting on a red horse among the myrtle trees ([1:8](#)) is called the angel of the Lord (cp. [Gen 16:7–13](#); [Exod 23:23](#); [32:34](#); [Judg 13:21–22](#)).

Zechariah 1:14

My love . . . is passionate and strong: This phrase, sometimes translated as “I am very jealous,” reflects intense, single-minded devotion that could produce hatred and envy or zeal and devotion. God is jealous—as the one true and living God, he has exclusive rights to his creatures’ worship (see [Exod 20:5](#); [34:14](#)). • Jerusalem signifies the territories ruled by Judean kings; Mount Zion was the site of the Lord’s Temple.

Zechariah 1:17

The repetition of again (four times in Hebrew) emphasizes the certainty of God’s intention to restore Jerusalem.

Zechariah 1:18–19

Then I looked up suggests that the prophet was interrupted by another vision while still preoccupied with the previous one (also in [2:1](#); [5:1](#); [6:1](#)). • Horns symbolized power and authority in the biblical world and might represent an individual ruler (see [Dan 7:8](#); [8:8](#)), a dynasty, or nations.

Zechariah 1:18–21

The second vision states God’s plan to bring his judgment against the nations who destroyed Jerusalem and exiled Judah. The prophet leaves unspecified the identity of the nations represented by the four horns; it is best to view the number four as symbolic of all those nations who will face divine judgment for scattering the people of God.

Zechariah 1:20

The word translated blacksmiths could refer to any sort of craftsmen (mason, carpenter, smith). If the horns representing the nations were metal (see [1 Kgs 22:11](#)), then blacksmiths were appropriate to the task of destroying them (see [2 Chr 24:12](#); [Isa 44:12](#)).

Zechariah 1:21

humbled Judah: They literally *lifted up their horns against Judah*. • The Lord would cut off those horns, throw them down to the ground, and bring an end to their authority. The Judeans did not need to fear the surrounding nations.

Zechariah 2:1–5

The scope of the visions narrows from the cosmos (vision 1), to the nations (vision 2), to the city of Jerusalem. The vision itself ([2:1–3](#)) is followed by an explanation of its meaning ([2:4–5](#)).

Zechariah 2:2

how wide and how long it is (Or *how long and wide it is to be*): By taking this measurement, God showed that he was planning for Jerusalem’s future.

Zechariah 2:5

The wall of fire represents divine protection (cp. [2 Kgs 6:17](#)). • I, myself, will be: The emphatic construction of the verb “to be” might be a direct reference to God’s name ([Exod 3:14–15](#)). • Fire and glory allude to the Exodus (see [Exod 13:22](#); [14:20](#); [40:34](#)).

Zechariah 2:6

Come away! The emphatic command carries the force of a promise that the Lord would lead his people out of exile and into a restored Jerusalem (cp. [Isa 55:1](#)). • the land of the north: It was necessary to travel north in order to move to the east, so Babylonia was thought of as lying in the north. • four winds: The Hebrew exiles would return to Judah and Jerusalem from all directions (see [Ezek 12:14](#); [37:9](#)).

Zechariah 2:6–13

God’s call for the exiles’ return from Babylon anticipated his people’s restoration to the land of Israel ([2:6–9](#)) and the restoration of his presence to his people in Jerusalem ([2:10–13](#)).

Zechariah 2:8

Anyone who harms you harms my most precious possession (literally *Anyone who touches you touches the pupil of his eye*): This might refer to Israel as God's elect; it might also mean that those who harmed Israel poked themselves in the eye by bringing God's judgment upon themselves.

Zechariah 2:9

their own slaves will plunder them: At the Exodus, the Egyptians paid the Israelites to leave their land (see [Exod 11:2-3](#); [12:35-36](#)).

Zechariah 2:12

Israel is the Lord's inheritance or special possession—the people of Israel belonged to the Lord ([Deut 32:9-10](#)). • The land was holy because of God's glorious presence in the Jerusalem Temple (see [Pss 11:4](#); [15:1](#)).

Zechariah 2:13

Be silent: The force of the Hebrew word (has) is similar to our English word “hush” (see [Hab 2:20](#); [Zeph 1:7](#)).

Zechariah 3:1

Jeshua was the high priest, the religious leader among those who returned to Judah from exile in Babylon ([Ezra 2:2](#)). Jeshua partnered with Zerubbabel, the governor of the restored community, in rebuilding the Jerusalem Temple ([Ezra 5:2](#); [Hag 2:1-5](#)). • The Accuser, Satan (literally *The satan*) designates a member of the heavenly court whose role is to accuse human beings of wrongdoing, to act as prosecuting attorney (see [Job 1:6](#)). The adversarial role may be performed by either human or divine beings (see [Num 22:22](#); [1 Sam 29:4](#); [1 Chr 21:1](#)). By New Testament times, *Satan* was a personal name for the prince of demons ([Mark 3:22](#); [2 Cor 4:4](#); [Eph 6:11](#); [Rev 20:2](#)). • The Accuser's position of authority in the heavenly court is shown by his standing at the angel's right hand.

Zechariah 3:1-10

The prophet's vision depicts a heavenly courtroom with the prosecuting attorney (Satan) accusing the defendant (Jeshua the high priest) of being unfit for his priestly duties.

Zechariah 3:2-3

The Lord is both defense attorney and judge; he censures the prosecution's arguments, dismisses the case, and declares Jeshua innocent because he has been chosen and cleansed by God. • Like a burning stick that has been snatched from the fire, Jeshua and other Hebrew exiles were plucked by God from near destruction in Babylon. • Jeshua's filthy clothes ([3:4](#)) symbolize the guilt and pollution of sin that prompted the divine judgment of exile. The accusations of Satan probably implied that just as a polluted priest was unfit for Temple service, the Hebrews were unfit to be God's chosen people.

Zechariah 3:4

Take off his filthy clothes: This action dramatizes the removal of sin and guilt from Jeshua and the Hebrew people, restoring them to their former position through God's cleansing.

Zechariah 3:5

The high priest's turban bore a gold medallion inscribed with the words “Holy to the Lord” ([Exod 28:36-38](#); see also study note on Zech 14:20). The clean turban was placed on Jeshua's head as an act of ordination that reinstated him as priest and mediator for the people.

Zechariah 3:6-7

Restoration was contingent upon obedience to God (see also [Deut 30:19-20](#)).

Zechariah 3:8

The high priest Jeshua and the other priests were symbols of greater realities. • Servant and Branch are both titles for the Messiah ([Isa 42:1](#); [53:2](#); [Jer 23:5](#); [33:15](#)). As servant, the Messiah obeys God's will by becoming a sin offering so that many might be made righteous ([Isa 53:11](#); see [Acts 3:13](#); [4:27](#)). The Branch is a metaphor for kingship that identifies the Messiah as David's descendant ([Isa 11:1](#); [Jer 23:5](#)).

Zechariah 3:9

The single stone signifies authority. It might refer to the final stone of the Temple laid by Zerubbabel ([4:7](#)), the "foundation stone" of the restored Jerusalem ([Isa 28:16](#)), or the precious stones on the ephod of the high priests ([Exod 25:7](#); [35:9](#)). • The seven facets (literally *seven eyes*) of the stone imply perfection and completeness of knowledge and wisdom. They might relate to the seven lamps of the golden lampstand ([Zech 4:2](#)) or to God's "sevenfold Spirit" ([Rev 1:4](#)). • The inscription is reminiscent of the names of the tribes inscribed on the stones of the high priest's shoulder-pieces ([Exod 39:6](#)). • The removal of Israel's sin in a single day alludes to the Day of Atonement ([Lev 16](#)). It foreshadows Christ's crucifixion, when the Lamb of God would take away the sin of the world ([John 1:29](#)).

Zechariah 3:10

That day is shorthand for "the day of the Lord" (see [2:11](#); [Isa 2:11](#); [Joel 2:1](#); [Zeph 1:14](#)), the day of God's intervention in history when God will judge the wicked, deliver the righteous, and restore creation (see [Zech 12:8](#); [14:3-4](#)).

Zechariah 4:1

woke me: The series of visions ([1:7-6:8](#)) came to Zechariah in a single night. The prophet slept briefly before this fifth vision.

Zechariah 4:1-14

This vision affirms that through his Spirit, God would enable Zerubbabel and Jeshua to rebuild the Temple.

Zechariah 4:2-3

gold lampstand: The golden menorah of the Tabernacle ([Exod 25:31](#)) was duplicated in the new Temple as a symbol of God's purity and holiness and the light of his revelation. • The two olive trees represent the offices of priest and king in Israel; they are emblems for Jeshua and Zerubbabel. The golden oil (see also [Zech 4:12-14](#)) represents God's Holy Spirit.

Zechariah 4:6

Jeshua and Zerubbabel would have success in the rebuilding of the Jerusalem Temple, not by their own force or strength, but because of the presence of God's empowering Spirit (cp. [Hag 2:4-5](#)).

Zechariah 4:7

A mighty mountain . . . will become a level plain is a figure of speech in both Old Testament (see [Isa 40:4](#); [49:11](#)) and New Testament (see [Matt 17:20](#); [1 Cor 13:2](#)). Faith in God enables his servants to overcome seemingly impossible obstacles. • The capstone or headstone (final stone) completes a stone wall or building (see [Ps 118:22](#)). • May God bless it!: This prayer seeks God's favor and blessing on the new Temple.

Zechariah 4:10

A plumb line, a cord with a tin or lead weight attached to one end, is used in construction to ensure that a wall is vertical. • The seven lamps: *Seven* signifies completeness or perfection. God sees all that takes place on earth; he controls the fates of peoples and nations.

Zechariah 4:14

two anointed ones: Jeshua and Zerubbabel, the religious and civic leaders of Jerusalem after the

return from exile ([3:1](#), [7](#); [4:6-7](#); [Hag 1:14](#); [2:2-3](#)), were anointed with oil as part of their commissioning. Under their leadership, the Temple of the Lord was rebuilt and worship was restored in Jerusalem.

Zechariah 5:1

looked up again: This is the sixth of eight visions that Zechariah had in the same night. • A scroll, the equivalent of a book in biblical times, was usually made of rolled parchment or leather, but was sometimes made of papyrus, tin, or copper. This scroll was flying, unfurled like a banner for all to see.

Zechariah 5:1-4

Zechariah's vision of the flying scroll reminded the leaders and people of postexilic Judah that they were still obligated to follow God's commands. The blessings and curses of the law ([Deut 28](#)) were still in effect.

Zechariah 5:3

curse (or *oath*): A covenant included curses on violators of the agreement (see [Deut 29:12-21](#)).

Zechariah 5:4

This curse is sent like a law officer to punish violations of God's covenant (see [Ps 147:15](#); [Isa 55:11](#)).

Zechariah 5:5-11

The seventh vision continues the theme of cleansing that began with the acquittal of the high priest Jeshua ([3:1-10](#)). The removal of wickedness, much like the removal of Jeshua's filthy garments ([3:4](#)), was a gracious act of pardon by the covenant-keeping God.

Zechariah 5:6

The basket (Hebrew ephah) was a standard unit of dry measure, approximately ½ bushel. The Old Testament prophets' condemnation of unjust ephahs creates a natural association between the ephah basket and evil (see [Ezek 45:10](#); [Mic 6:10](#)).

Zechariah 5:7

The heavy lead cover (literally *a talent* [seventy-five pounds] *of lead*) is not a natural cover for an ephah basket, but shows that extraordinary measures were needed to seal the basket's unholy contents.

Zechariah 5:7-8

The evil woman in a basket represents a seductive and dangerous force that is difficult to contain. The sin of idolatry had previously provoked God's judgment ([2 Kgs 17:16-18](#); [2 Chr 36:14](#)).

Zechariah 5:8

Wickedness refers to evil generally; whether moral or ceremonial, it is opposed to righteousness (see [Prov 13:6](#); [Ezek 33:12](#)). The word *wickedness* (Hebrew rish'ah) is similar in Hebrew to the name Asherah, the fertility goddess of the ancient Near East (see [Deut 7:5](#); [16:21](#)).

Zechariah 5:9

The depiction of divine or angelic winged creatures as women is unusual in the Old Testament. If the two women are the Lord's servants, they are unique angels. If they are the attendants of Wickedness (a foreign goddess), their submission to God's command demonstrates his power over false gods.

Zechariah 5:11

Idolatry is potently and aggressively evil; it cannot be confined, but must be shipped back to its source (Babylonia) by God's decree. This symbolism indicates that God is able to purge his people of all the various forms of wickedness that separated

them from him. • The land of Babylonia was the land of Hebrew captivity ([Mic 4:10](#)). The prophets condemn it as wicked and idolatrous ([Isa 46–47](#); [Jer 50–51](#)). In the New Testament, Babylon represents the evil Roman Empire ([Rev 17:5](#); [18:2](#); see [1 Pet 5:13](#)).

Zechariah 6:1

Chariots symbolize the swift and decisive power of God's intervention in human affairs. • The two bronze mountains are enhanced images of the two bronze pillars that once flanked the entrance to Solomon's Temple ([1 Kgs 7:13–22](#)). Bronze symbolizes the impregnable strength of God's dwelling.

Zechariah 6:1–8

In Zechariah's first and last visions, God sends horses to patrol the earth. Both visions show God's sovereignty and his concern for the nations, a vital component of Zechariah's message of comfort and encouragement to postexilic Judah.

Zechariah 6:2–3

red . . . black . . . white . . . dappled-gray horses: Zechariah attaches no particular significance to the colors of the horses in his vision (cp. [Rev 6:1–8](#)).

Zechariah 6:5

The four spirits (or *the four winds*) of heaven are divine council members who report to God on their reconnaissance missions to the four compass points (see [2:6](#)). The whole world is under God's dominion. The teams of chariot horses are agents of God's judgment.

Zechariah 6:7

The teams of horses are portrayed as powerful and eager to do the Lord's work ([6:5](#)). They move only at the Lord's command.

Zechariah 6:8

the Lord summoned me: The series of visions closes with a direct word from the Lord to Zechariah. In bypassing the interpreting angel, God emphasizes the sure and effective implementation of his word to Israel. • have vented the anger of my Spirit (literally *have given my Spirit rest*): "Spirit" can mean "anger," as it does here (see [Judg 8:3](#); [Isa 33:11](#)).

Zechariah 6:9–15

This authoritative message accompanies Zechariah's eighth vision ([6:1–8](#)). Jeshua's symbolic coronation as both king and priest was not an actual political arrangement for Judah; it probably symbolizes the coming of the Messiah, the Branch ([6:12](#); cp. [3:8](#)).

Zechariah 6:10

Heldai, Tobijah, and Jedaiah were apparently couriers designated by Jews in Babylon to carry donations to the Temple building fund.

Zechariah 6:11

This crown was probably made of two bands of metal, one gold and one silver. Each band represented one of the offices (king and priest) to which Jeshua was appointed.

Zechariah 6:12–13

The Branch is a title for the Messiah (see [3:8](#)), whom Jeshua represents. • he will build the Temple of the Lord: Just as Jeshua the high priest helped to build the Temple in Jerusalem ([Ezra 3:1–2](#), [8–9](#); [5:2](#)), Jesus the Messiah would build the eternal heavenly Temple through his death, burial, and resurrection ([John 2:19–22](#); [4:23–24](#); [Eph 2:19–22](#); [Heb 8:1–2](#)). • The Messiah would rule as king, a role associated with David and the tribe of Judah ([2 Sam 7:12–16](#)). • He will also serve as priest from his throne: The Messiah's priestly role is associated with Aaron and the tribe of Levi ([Exod 29:44](#)). • Jeshua's crown represents his two roles. Melchizedek also fulfilled the double functions of

priest and king ([Gen 14:17-20](#)), as does the Messiah ([Ps 110:4](#); [Heb 7:1-3](#), [15-17](#)).

Zechariah 6:14

The symbolic crown that united kingship and priesthood was placed in the Temple as a memorial to the donors of gold and silver. It was also a permanent reminder of Jeshua's coronation as priest-king and a visual aid for priests in teaching this new development. • Josiah was honored for his role as broker for the meeting between Zechariah and the three former exiles.

Zechariah 6:15

Exiled Jews in Babylon and other distant lands helped to rebuild the Temple; all Israel could identify with the structure.

Zechariah 7:1

of the fourth year of King Darius's reign: The two sermons of chs [7-8](#) came almost two years after the visions of chs [1-6](#).

Zechariah 7:1-14

Zechariah's sermons were prompted by delegates from Bethel who posed a practical question ([7:2-3](#)). Although Zechariah answered the question later ([8:18-19](#)), he responded first with rhetorical questions that focused on the people's self-centered motives ([7:5-6](#)). Zechariah then outlined God's expectations for Israel ([7:8-10](#); see [Jer 22:3](#)) and recounted what had happened to those who disobeyed previously ([Zech 7:11-14](#)).

Zechariah 7:1-8.23

These sermons provide a transition between the visions of the present (chs [1-6](#)) and those of the near future (chs [9-11](#)) and the more distant future (chs [12-14](#)). [Chapter 7](#) discusses fasting over past disasters; [chapter 8](#) focuses on feasting over future blessings.

Zechariah 7:2

to seek the Lord's favor (literally *to soften the face of the Lord*): They were asking God to grant a petition or to rule on a question. Their request was probably accompanied by a sacrifice or offering.

Zechariah 7:3

The delegation from Bethel posed a practical procedural question.

Zechariah 7:4-7

Rather than answering the question right away, Zechariah first confronted his hearers with their selfish motives and hypocrisy. The most important issue was whether or not their heart's desire was really to please God and do his will; if not, it made no difference whether or not they kept a fast.

Zechariah 7:5

According to Jeremiah, seventy years of exile in Babylon (see [Jer 25:11-12](#); [29:10](#)) were to make up the Sabbath years of rest for the land that had gone unobserved for nearly 500 years ([2 Chr 36:21](#); see [Exod 23:10-11](#); [Lev 26:34-35](#)). • While the summer fast lamented the destruction of Solomon's Temple ([Zech 7:3](#)), the early autumn fast either commemorated the assassination of Gedaliah, governor of Judah (see [2 Kgs 25:22-25](#); [Jer 41:1-3](#)), or it was the Day of Atonement ([Lev 23:26-32](#)).

Zechariah 7:7

Isn't this the same message: E.g., see [Isa 1:11-20](#); [58:3-7](#).

Zechariah 7:10

Widows, orphans, foreigners, and the poor often did not have access to the legal protection afforded the average citizen (cp. [Deut 24:14, 17-18](#)). Fasting and social justice should go hand in hand (see [Isa 58:6-7](#)).

Zechariah 7:11

Your ancestors refused to listen: They ignored God's commands (see [Jer 11:10](#)). • stubbornly turned away (or *set a defiant shoulder*): The idiom signifies haughty stubbornness (see [Neh 9:29](#)). • Put their fingers in their ears places full responsibility upon the people for their obstinacy (cp. [Isa 6:10](#)). The same expression is used of Pharaoh when he "became stubborn" (or "hardened his heart") against God and refused to release the Hebrews ([Exod 8:32](#)).

Zechariah 7:12

To make one's heart as hard as stone is to steel one's will against the will of God (see [Jer 17:1](#); cp. [Ezek 3:9](#)). • Instructions (Hebrew torah) refers to God's laws and commands as taught and interpreted by the prophets.

Zechariah 7:14

As with a whirlwind, I scattered them: The scattering of the Hebrews among the nations was one of the curses for violating the Mosaic covenant ([Deut 28:36-37, 64](#)). • The pleasant land was the land of God's covenant promise ([Ps 106:24](#); [Jer 3:19](#)). • Their land became . . . desolate through divine judgment on their covenant unfaithfulness and idolatry ([Jer 12:10](#)).

Zechariah 8:1-23

This section of Zechariah's sermons is connected to the previous one by the topics of fasting (questions posed in [7:2-7](#) are answered in [8:18-19](#)) and the ethical demands of covenant relationship with the Lord ([7:8-10](#); [8:16-17](#)). The tone and message shift from admonition and judgment to exhortation and restoration. Fasting would change to feasting ([8:19](#)).

Zechariah 8:2

Passion (or *jealousy, zeal*) is a basic element of the Old Testament concept of God (see also [1:14](#)). God's passion identifies him as a personal deity, not an abstract natural force. God is passionate for his word and for the people of his covenant. His

passion results in punishment for sin, restoration for repentance, and reward for the pursuit of righteousness.

Zechariah 8:3

I will live in Jerusalem: The great hope of the postexilic community was that the Lord would return to dwell among his people again (see [1:16-17](#); [Hag 2:4-7](#); cp. [Ezek 48:35](#)). • I am returning: God would return to Jerusalem not just because the Temple had been rebuilt but because the Hebrew community had been purified ([Zech 3](#)). • Isaiah compared Jerusalem to a faithful woman who became a prostitute ([Isa 1:21](#)). Zechariah shared Isaiah's vision of Jerusalem's change into a Faithful City (or *city of truth*) again ([Isa 1:26](#)).

Zechariah 8:4-5

The images of old men and women walking and of boys and girls playing in the streets indicate repopulation and resumption of normal family life in the once decimated city of Jerusalem. The return of God's presence to his rebuilt Temple would bring peace and safety to the city's inhabitants (see [Jer 33:10-11](#)).

Zechariah 8:6

The Old Testament portrays God as able to do the impossible and the miraculous—nothing is too hard for the God who made the heavens and the earth ([Gen 18:14](#); [Jer 32:17, 27](#); see also [Matt 19:26](#)).

Zechariah 8:7

from the east and from the west: This is an idiom meaning *from all the regions to which the Hebrews were dispersed* (compare [Isa 43:5-6](#)).

Zechariah 8:8

They will be my people, and I will be . . . their God: This adoption formula depicts the intimate bond between Israel and God in covenant relationship (see [Exod 19:5-6](#); [Jer 30:22](#); [31:33](#); [Ezek 34:30-31](#); [Hos 2:23](#)).

Zechariah 8:9

Laying of the foundation refers to Zerubbabel's and Jeshua's initial work of rebuilding the Temple in 536 BC ([Ezra 3:8-13](#)). The Temple reconstruction project was quickly abandoned and was not resumed until the prophets Haggai and Zechariah prompted it sixteen years later ([Ezra 5:1-2](#); [Hag 1:1](#)).

Zechariah 8:9-13

This section highlights the reversal of Jerusalem's fortunes as the Temple was rebuilt (cp. [2 Chr 15:3-7](#)). The exhortation to be strong ([Zech 8:9, 13](#)) is an *inclusio* (a set of rhetorical bookends) for the section.

Zechariah 8:10

enemies: The neighboring peoples opposed the rebuilding of the Temple ([Ezra 4](#)). Later, enemies opposed Nehemiah's rebuilding of the wall around Jerusalem ([Neh 4](#)).

Zechariah 8:12

Peace (Hebrew *shalom*) is an important theme underlying Zechariah's message ([8:10, 12, 16, 19](#)). God's presence in the rebuilt Temple would bring peace to Judah (see [Hag 2:6-9](#)). Zechariah uses the agricultural cycle to represent God's blessing (see [Hag 2:18-19](#)), which would reverse the drought conditions that Haggai described ([Hag 1:10](#)). • The small community that returned to Judah from exile was called the remnant. Theologically, the remnant is a bridge between God's punishment and his promised restoration (see [Hag 1:12, 14](#)).

Zechariah 8:14-15

determined: The repetition of this word emphasizes God's sovereignty in judging Israel's sin and then in blessing them.

Zechariah 8:16

God expects his people to act with integrity and justice (see [Eph 4:25](#)). • The courts (literally *the gates*): Legal proceedings were conducted at the gates of the city or Temple (see [Deut 21:19](#); [25:7](#)).

Zechariah 8:17

In Zechariah's time, the people of Judah were guilty of the same sins that brought about the Babylonian exile. Such behavior put God's plans for restoration in jeopardy (see [7:8-10](#); [8:16](#)). • I hate all these things: God's hatred of evil ([Ps 5:5](#); [Prov 6:16-19](#)) stems from his absolute holiness ([Pss 5:4](#); [15:1](#); [24:3](#)).

Zechariah 8:19

Here the Lord finally answers the question posed by the delegates from Bethel ([7:2-3](#)). • The fast in early summer commemorated the breaching of Jerusalem's walls ([2 Kgs 25:3-4](#); [Jer 52:6-7](#)). The midsummer fast lamented the burning of Solomon's Temple ([2 Kgs 25:8-10](#); [Jer 52:12-14](#)). The fast in autumn marked the assassination of Gedaliah, governor of Jerusalem ([2 Kgs 25:22-25](#); [Jer 41:1-3](#)) or the Day of Atonement ([Lev 23:26-32](#)). The fast in winter recalled the beginning of the siege of Jerusalem ([2 Kgs 25:1](#); [Jer 52:4](#)). • The fasts will turn to feasts when God restores Israel and sets his glory among the nations ([Isa 65:18-19](#)).

Zechariah 8:23

God is with you: God's presence restored the ideal of fellowship between God and human beings ([Gen 3:8](#); [Exod 24:9-11](#); [25:8](#); [Isa 7:14](#); [57:15](#); [Ezek 43:7](#); [John 1:14](#)).

Zechariah 9:1

The land of Aram was a city-state on the northern boundary of Israel, on the caravan route connecting Mesopotamia to the Mediterranean coast. Aram was sometimes an ally and sometimes an enemy to Israel and Judah. • Damascus, the capital of Aram, was the northern boundary of the ideal Hebrew state ([Ezek 47:16-18](#)).

Zechariah 9:1–8

This encouraging message told the Judeans that they had nothing to fear from their three most prominent neighbors—Syria (Aram), the Phoenicians (Tyre and Sidon), and the Philistines. All three were rivals of Judah; they were always trying to take commercial and territorial advantage. God said that their efforts would be in vain.

Zechariah 9:1–11.17

This is the message: This is the *superscription* (introductory heading) for the entire section; it includes the technical term message (or *oracle*, *burden*), a prophetic pronouncement of judgment; the use of this word invests the message with divine authority. These prophecies can be related to events between Zechariah's time and the coming of Christ.

Zechariah 9:1–14.21

The second part of Zechariah stands apart from the first in several ways. [Zechariah 9–14](#) is distinctively apocalyptic, combining cryptic historical allusions with futuristic visions. The messages alternate between threats of judgment for other nations and promises of deliverance for Israel. The section contains no explicit references to Zechariah, but uses God's direct speech. The messages probably date from a later period in Zechariah's ministry.

Zechariah 9:2

Hamath, a fortress city on one of the southern trade routes from Asia Minor, was on the northern boundary of Israel (see [Num 13:21](#); [Josh 13:5](#)). • The twin port cities of Tyre and Sidon were independent Phoenician kingdoms located on the Mediterranean coast north of Israel (modern-day Lebanon); they are often paired in biblical texts (e.g., [Ezra 3:7](#); [Joel 3:4](#); [Luke 10:13–14](#)). The cities were legendary for their maritime trade wealth, but Old Testament prophets condemned their pride and oppressive policies and predicted their destruction ([Isa 23](#); [Ezek 26:3–14](#); [Amos 1:9–10](#)).

Zechariah 9:3–4

Strong fortress (Hebrew matsor) is a pun on the name of the city of Tyre (Hebrew tsor). This famed island fortress ([Isa 23:4](#); [Ezek 26:5](#)) was captured and destroyed by Alexander the Great in 332 BC.

Zechariah 9:5–6

Ashkelon . . . Gaza . . . Ekron . . . Ashdod: These Philistine cities, located on the coastal plain of Israel, were defeated by David ([2 Sam 5:17–25](#)) but later regained some autonomy. The prophets Amos and Zephaniah pronounced similar judgments against the same four cities ([Amos 1:6–8](#); [Zeph 2:4–7](#)).

Zechariah 9:6

Foreigners: This Hebrew word occurs elsewhere only in [Deut 23:2](#), where it refers to illegitimate children. Zechariah uses it to signify the Philistines' eventual loss of political and social identity.

Zechariah 9:7

bloody meat: The Philistines ate meat that had not been drained of blood and was therefore unclean ([Gen 9:4](#); [Lev 3:17](#); [Acts 15:20](#)). • Detestable sacrifices suggests eating unclean foods (see [Lev 11:2–23](#)). • the surviving Philistines will worship our God: This anticipates Philip's ministry in the cities of the Philistine coastal plain ([Acts 8:40](#)). • The Jebusites were a Canaanite group (see [Gen 10:16](#); [1 Chr 1:14](#)) living in and around Jerusalem. The city of Jebus (Jerusalem) was sacked and burned during the days of the judges ([Judg 1:8](#)); it was later recaptured by David, who made it the capital of his kingdom ([2 Sam 5:6–10](#)). The Jebusites were absorbed by the Israelites through intermarriage during David's reign (see [2 Sam 5:13](#)).

Zechariah 9:9

Your king refers to a future king from David's line, described earlier as the Branch ([3:8](#); [6:12–13](#)). • The donkey was a humble animal, and riding on a donkey signaled that its rider came in peace (see [Matt 21:5](#); [John 12:15](#)).

Zechariah 9:9-17

The second message of Zechariah's first oracle (chs [9-11](#)) presents the juxtaposition of warfare and peace that has defined human history. Judah's coming deliverer-king will be victorious in battle, yet righteous and humble ([9:9](#)), and he will bring peace to the nations in his universal reign ([9:10](#)).

Zechariah 9:10

As used here, Israel stands in contrast to Judah, the southern kingdom. The pairing of Israel and Jerusalem signifies a reunited Israel and the regaining of the covenant land. • The kingdoms of Assyria, Babylonia, Persia, and Israel were established by military conquest. By contrast, the kingdom of the Messiah will dismantle the machinery of war and eradicate all arsenals of weapons (see [Isa 2:4](#); [9:5](#); [Mic 5:10-11](#); [Joel 3:10](#)). • The Euphrates River was the northern boundary of the Promised Land ([Gen 15:18](#)). • the ends of the earth: The righteous king will establish universal peace.

Zechariah 9:11

The covenant . . . sealed with blood probably refers to the blood sacrifice that sealed the Mosaic covenant ([Exod 24:8](#)). • The prisoners were Jews still living as exiles in Mesopotamia after the Babylonian exile. The Jews who remained in Persia and Babylon were spiritual exiles because they lived outside the Promised Land of spiritual blessing and rest (see [Deut 12:10](#)). One of the Messiah's defining activities would be to free prisoners ([Isa 61:1](#); [Luke 4:17-22](#); [Rom 7:6](#); [Eph 4:8](#)).

Zechariah 9:12

Come back to the place of safety: This is a call for the Jews still in Babylon to return to the land of Judah.

Zechariah 9:13

The Persians and the Greeks were engaged in a power struggle in Zechariah's time. In the future, God would judge the Greeks (who could represent all Gentiles). Zechariah is possibly alluding to Daniel's vision ([Dan 8:21-22](#)).

Zechariah 9:14

appear above his people: Zechariah borrows the image of a winged sun disk that artists pictured as protectively hovering over the Persian king. The Lord will protect Israel, go before them in battle, and show them his power. • The ram's horn issues a summons ([Num 10:2-3](#), [7-10](#); [Isa 27:13](#)) and declares God's presence and power ([Exod 19:19](#); [20:18](#)). • The whirlwind depicts God as a warrior of devastating power and unpredictable swiftness ([Ps 77:18](#); [Isa 21:1](#); [29:6](#); [66:15](#)). References to lightning bring Mount Sinai to mind ([Exod 19:16](#)) and with it God's covenant promises to Israel.

Zechariah 9:15

In ancient battles, great stones (literally *sling-stones*) were hurled at defenders on city walls and catapulted onto the inhabitants inside. The Maccabees' triumph over the Hellenistic Seleucids in the 100s BC might have partially fulfilled Zechariah's prophecy of Israel's defeat of the Greeks (see *1 Maccabees* 3:16-24; 4:6-16; 7:40-50). • They will be filled with blood . . . drenched with blood: When the Lord unleashes his armies against the Greeks, the amount of bloodshed will be vast. • like a bowl: Ceremonial sprinkling bowls filled with animal blood were used in the rituals of sacrifice. This image almost suggests that the vanquishing of the Lord's enemies is in some sense an offering to him (see [Exod 24:6](#); [Lev 1:5](#); [16:18](#)).

Zechariah 9:16

On that day: See study note on 3:10. • The Old Testament prophets portrayed the Messiah as a king and as a faithful shepherd (see [Ezek 34:12](#), [16](#), [23](#); [37:24](#); [John 10:1](#); [Heb 13:20](#); [1 Pet 5:4](#)).

Zechariah 9:17

abundant grain . . . new wine: Agricultural prosperity was a tangible sign of God's blessing (see [Joel 2:19](#); [Amos 9:13](#); cp. [Hag 1:11](#)).

Zechariah 10:1

Rain was a sign of divine blessing (see [Joel 2:23](#))—the Lord was the source of the rain, but Israel's leaders had led the people to trust in false gods instead.

Zechariah 10:1–3

This is a rebuke of false shepherds, human leaders who do not have their people's good at heart.

Zechariah 10:1–11.3

God will strengthen his people by his power and restore them because of his compassion ([10:6, 12](#)). With its references to shepherds ([10:2–3](#); [11:3](#)), the passage prepares for the following allegory of the good and evil shepherds ([11:4–17](#)).

Zechariah 10:2

Household gods might refer to ancestor statues used in rituals of necromancy (conjuring up the spirits of the dead); consultation with the dead was a widespread practice in the ancient world, but God's law made it taboo for the Hebrews (see [Lev 20:27](#); [Deut 18:10–11](#)).

Zechariah 10:3

My anger burns: Israel is often the object of this divine wrath, incited by disobedience to covenant stipulations or by lapses into idolatry (see [Exod 22:22–24](#); [Deut 6:14–15](#); [Josh 7:1](#); [Judg 2:20](#); [Heb 10:31](#)). • these leaders (or *these male goats*): This is a figure of speech for princes, since male goats typically lead goat herds.

Zechariah 10:4

A cornerstone is the first-laid foundation stone upon which a building's superstructure rests (see [Job 38:6](#); [Ps 118:22](#); [Isa 28:16](#); [Eph 2:20](#)). • Just as a tent peg anchors a tent to the ground, so Judah will provide the future leaders needed to stabilize the Hebrew nation. • Many understand cornerstone, tent peg, and bow for battle as titles for the Messiah (cp. [Isa 22:20–23](#); [Zech 9:13](#)).

Zechariah 10:4–12

A true shepherd is promised.

Zechariah 10:6

save: This Hebrew word is also used for the exodus from Egypt (see [Exod 14:30](#)). Salvation and victory come from God ([Ps 3:8](#); [Isa 63:1](#)). • God saves and restores his people Israel because of his compassion (see [Exod 33:19](#); [Pss 103:13](#); [111:4](#); [Lam 3:32](#)).

Zechariah 10:8

When I whistle to them: Shepherds in biblical times herded their flocks by whistling or piping to them (see [Judg 5:16](#)). • Redeemed can also mean “ransomed”—buying slaves out of their servitude or indentured status (see [Deut 15:15](#); [24:18](#)). • numerous as . . . before: The proliferation of the Hebrew people was one of God's covenant promises to Abraham ([Gen 12:1–3](#); [22:17](#); [32:12](#)).

Zechariah 10:10

The Lord had previously whistled for the armies of Egypt and Assyria to come against King Ahaz of Judah because of his unbelief ([Isa 7:18](#)). The two nations were especially symbolic of the slavery and exile endured by the Hebrews. • Gilead is a fertile region east of the Jordan River and south of the Sea of Galilee that is suitable for grain growing and pasturing; it was settled by the tribes of Manasseh and Gad. • Lebanon sometimes defined the northern edge of the Promised Land (see [Deut 11:24](#); [Josh 1:4](#)). God's restoration and resettlement of the Hebrews would be so complete

that even the fringe areas of Israelite territory would teem with people.

Zechariah 10:11

When the Hebrews returned to the land of Israel from exile in Babylon, they had to ford the Euphrates River; this is likened to a second exodus from Egypt (see [Isa 43:2-6](#), [16-17](#)).

Zechariah 10:12

This verse repeats the earlier promise that God would strengthen his people ([10:6](#); see [Isa 41:8-10](#); cp. [Pss 18:1](#); [22:19](#); [28:8](#); [29:11](#)).

Zechariah 11:1

Lebanon, boasting snow-covered mountains and fruitful valleys, was a symbol of strength and fertility.

Zechariah 11:1-3

This taunt song against Lebanon and Bashan concludes the preceding message of deliverance and restoration for Israel ([10:1-12](#)); it could also introduce the following message about good and evil shepherds ([11:4-17](#)).

Zechariah 11:2

Like Lebanon, Bashan had superb stands of timber. Lebanon and Bashan are often paired ([Isa 2:13](#); [Jer 22:20-22](#); [Ezek 27:5-6](#)) in representing nations that God would judge when he would regather and restore the people of Israel (see [Zech 10:11](#)).

Zechariah 11:3

Shepherds and lions figuratively represent the leaders of Lebanon and Bashan, lamenting the destruction of their forested slopes, their pride, and their livelihood (see [11:1-2](#)).

Zechariah 11:4

The people of Israel are God's flock (see [Isa 40:11](#); [Mic 5:4](#)). The relative helplessness of sheep places a premium on their careful shepherding. • intended for slaughter: Like sheep fattened for butchering, the people are being treated as disposable goods in a corrupt economy.

Zechariah 11:4-17

The metaphor of the Hebrew leaders as shepherds binds together the last three messages ([9:9-11:17](#)) of Zechariah's first oracle (chs [9-11](#)). This message combines allegory with symbolic action on Zechariah's part to dramatize the wickedness of Israel's shepherds. The prophet acts out a parable of a "good shepherd" called by God to lead and unite his people, but the people reject this shepherd along with the promise of protection from the nations ([11:10](#)) and unity between Judah and Israel ([11:14](#)). Zechariah's symbolic actions foreshadow the ministry of Jesus the Messiah as the Good Shepherd (see [John 10:1-21](#)).

Zechariah 11:5

The sheep (the Hebrew people) were being sold as slaves to buyers—occupying foreign powers, foreign allies, or domestic slave-traders (see [Amos 2:6](#)). • The sellers were the shepherds, leaders of the people who were more concerned with getting rich than with the well-being of the sheep.

Zechariah 11:7

Shepherd's staffs symbolize leadership and authority. • Favor: This staff symbolized God's choice of Israel as his people (see [Gen 12:1-3](#)) and the promise of a leader like King David (see [2 Sam 7:12-16](#)). • Union: Ezekiel's staff ([Ezek 37:16-17](#)) represented the unity of the Hebrew tribes as a single nation during King David's reign ([2 Sam 5:1-3](#)).

Zechariah 11:8

The enigmatic historical reference to three evil shepherds has prompted more than forty different attempts to identify them. None of these

explanations is effective. *Three* symbolizes completeness. God raises up good shepherds to remove evil shepherds for the well-being of his people.

Zechariah 11:9

devour each other! This might refer literally to the cannibalism that resulted from famine during the siege of Jerusalem in 588–586 BC (see [Lam 4:10](#)) and later in AD 70 (see Josephus, *War* 7.4.4). The expression may also be a metaphor for various forms of exploitation and oppression (see [Mic 3:3](#); [Gal 5:15](#)).

Zechariah 11:10

Unlike Ezekiel, who dramatized the reunification of the Hebrew kingdoms ([Ezek 37:15–19](#)), Zechariah dramatized the division by cutting the staffs in two (see also [Zech 11:14](#)). The cutting of the staffs indicated the broken covenant bond between God and his people ([11:11](#)) and the broken bond of unity between the kingdoms of Judah and Israel ([11:14](#)). • A covenant between the Lord and all the nations is otherwise unknown. Zechariah might actually have been proclaiming the dissolution of the covenant binding Israel to God as his people (cp. [Hos 1:6–9](#); see study note on Zech 13:9).

Zechariah 11:12

Thirty pieces of silver was the price of a slave (see [Exod 21:32](#)). In the allegory, the silver was severance pay for the shepherd ([Zech 11:9](#)). The Gospel writers find the fulfillment of this passage in the betrayal of Jesus for thirty silver coins by Judas (see [Matt 26:15](#); [27:9–10](#)).

Zechariah 11:13

to the potter: Some scholars speculate that a guild of potters might have been minor Temple officials due to the continual need for sacred vessels (see [Lev 6:28](#)). Others, noting the similarity between *potter* (Hebrew *yotser*) and *treasury* ('otsar), follow the Syriac version, which reads *into the treasury* (see [Matt 27:6](#), [10](#); cp. [Jer 32:6–9](#)). The Greek Old Testament translates this sentence as “throw it into the furnace,” suggesting that the

silver was melted down and recast into a silver vessel for use in Temple rituals. • Thirty coins (or *pieces of silver*) was a magnificent sum of money (nearly two years' wages for the average laborer).

Zechariah 11:15

The worthless shepherd represents corrupt leaders, in contrast with the good shepherd (cp. [Ezek 34:7–16](#)).

Zechariah 11:16

Tear off their hooves is a Hebrew idiom for a wanton and ravenous search for the last morsel of edible meat on an animal carcass (see [Mic 3:3](#)).

Zechariah 11:17

This oracle of woe is a poetic curse against the worthless shepherd for abandoning the flock. The arm and right eye represent the physical and mental abilities of the shepherd. The maimed arm and blind eye make the worthless shepherd powerless and end his selfish, opportunistic rule.

Zechariah 12:1–14:21

The theme of Jerusalem versus the nations binds the four messages of Zechariah's second oracle together; the nations are gathered against Jerusalem at the beginning ([12:1–9](#)) and the end ([14:1–15](#)) of the oracle. Through the repetition of the phrase on that day, the oracle looks to the future day of the Lord. The picture it presents mixes judgment with blessing for Jerusalem. The oracle's focal point is the cleansing of the people of Israel ([13:1](#)); it culminates with God's universal Kingdom ([14:16–21](#)). These visions of the future encouraged the Judeans of Zechariah's day to be faithful in spite of their seeming insignificance and helplessness.

Zechariah 12:2

intoxicating drink (literally *bowl of reeling* or *cup of staggering*): The cup of alcoholic drink is a metaphor for God's judgment ([Isa 51:17](#); [Jer 25:15](#); [Hab 2:16](#); [Matt 26:39](#), [42](#); [Rev 14:10](#); [16:1](#)).

Jerusalem would be instrumental in God's judgment on the nearby nations.

Zechariah 12:3

Jerusalem will be an immovable rock that cuts and gashes those who attempt to conquer and control it, because the city was founded by the Lord, who loves it more than any other city of Israel ([Ps 87:1-2](#)). In Zechariah, imagery involving a stone is associated with the Temple ([Zech 3:9](#); [4:7](#); [10:4](#)).

Zechariah 12:4

Madness, blindness, and panic were among the curses threatened against Israel for covenant disobedience ([Deut 28:28](#)). The day of the Lord will witness a reversal as these curses are turned against Israel's enemies (see [2 Kgs 7:6-7](#)). • watch over (literally *open my eyes*): The open eyes of God represent divine provision for those in desperate need (see [Gen 16:13-14](#); [21:19-21](#)).

Zechariah 12:5

the Lord of Heaven's Armies: This title emphasizes God's irrepressible power (see study note on 1:3). The frequent repetition of this title in Zechariah's second oracle (chs [12-14](#)) assured his audience that the divine promises concerning Judah's victory would certainly be fulfilled ([12:7](#)).

Zechariah 12:6

flame (literally *firepan*): Bronze or gold firepans were used to carry hot coals to and from the sacrificial altars of the Tabernacle and the Temple ([Exod 27:3](#); [1 Kgs 7:50](#)). God would set Israel among the nations like a burning firepan to destroy or purify them.

Zechariah 12:8

The angel of the Lord is here equated with God, represented as a Divine Warrior, rescuer, and protector (see [1:11](#); [3:1](#); [Exod 14:19](#); [15:3](#); [Isa 59:15-20](#); [63:1-6](#)). By divine enabling, the weak will be imbued with God's power.

Zechariah 12:10

pour out: This word describes the outpouring of God's spirit of prophecy upon Israel and all people on the day of the Lord (cp. [Ezek 39:28-29](#); [Joel 2:28-29](#)) and God's judgment upon the wicked ([Lam 2:4](#); [Hos 5:10](#); [Zeph 3:8](#)). • a spirit of grace: God's unmerited and unsought favor persuades God's people to seek him in contrite and repentant prayer (see [Ps 86:15-16](#)). • me whom they have pierced: The New Testament understands the piercing of God as a reference to the piercing of the Messiah, Jesus of Nazareth ([John 19:34-37](#); [Rev 1:7](#)).

Zechariah 12:11

The name Hadad-rimmon combines the names of two Syrian deities, the storm-god Hadad and the thunder-god Rimmon. The great mourning for these gods may be similar to the weeping for Tammuz, one of the rituals practiced in the Mesopotamian fertility cults. • Joshua captured Megiddo ([Josh 12:21](#)), a major city on the southwest edge of the Jezreel Valley; it was allotted to the tribe of Manasseh ([Josh 17:11](#)). Megiddo controlled a key pass on the great highway from Egypt to Mesopotamia, and so was of great strategic importance. It was a district capital during Solomon's reign ([1 Kgs 4:12](#)). King Josiah was mortally wounded in a battle against Pharaoh Neco and the Egyptians on the plain of Megiddo ([2 Chr 35:22-23](#)), and the mountain of Megiddo is the site of the great battle depicted in [Rev 16:16](#).

Zechariah 12:12-14

The clan of David . . . Nathan . . . Levi, and . . . Shimei: Zechariah might be referring to the royal families (David and his son Nathan; see [1 Chr 14:4](#)) and the priestly families (Levi and his grandson Shimei; see [Num 3:16-18](#); [1 Chr 6:16-17](#)). Alternatively, the four families might represent the four principal classes of leadership in Old Testament times: the king (David, [1 Sam 16:1-13](#); the prophet (Nathan, [2 Sam 7:2](#)), the priest (Levi, [Deut 33:8-11](#)), and the tribal leader (Shimei, [1 Kgs 1:8](#); [4:18](#)). The first interpretation correlates with Zechariah's emphasis on the Branch that will be both king and priest (see [Zech 6:12-13](#)). • each clan by itself: This

separation depicts the depth and totality of Israel's mourning.

Zechariah 13:1

A fountain is a spring of pure, flowing water for cleansing and purification (see [14:8](#); [John 4:14](#); [Rev 22:1-2](#)). • God's cleansing of Israel will include leaders (represented by the dynasty of David) and all the people of Judah and Israel (signified by the people of Jerusalem, the spiritual center of the nation). • to cleanse them: This cleansing, symbolized in the ritual washings of Old Testament worship (see [Exod 30:17-21](#)), was provided in the new covenant as promised by Jeremiah ([Jer 31:34](#)) and Ezekiel ([Ezek 36:25](#); see [Heb 10:1-22](#)). • all their sins and impurity: The Hebrews would experience a complete moral and spiritual cleansing because of their sorrow over their sin ([Zech 12:10-14](#)).

Zechariah 13:1-6

The second message ([13:1-6](#)) of the second oracle (chs [12-14](#)) focuses on cleansing from sin.

Zechariah 13:2

By cleansing Israel, God would erase their former penchant for idol worship, giving them a new heart and enabling them to worship God alone ([Jer 31:33](#); [32:38-40](#); [Ezek 36:25-28](#)). • In the biblical world, one's name embodied one's existence. When the names of the idols are forgotten, they cease to exist. • The false prophets misrepresented God by fabricating divine revelations or by speaking in the name of other gods ([Deut 13:5-11](#); [18:17-22](#)). They led Israel astray by encouraging idol worship ([Jer 23:13, 25](#)) and would continue to do so (see [Neh 6:12-14](#); [Mark 13:22](#); [2 Pet 2:1](#); [1 Jn 4:1-3](#)) until that day, the day of the Lord.

Zechariah 13:3

You must die: According to God's law, a false prophet must be executed ([Deut 13:5, 10](#); [18:20](#)). The Israelites had tolerated false prophets and killed the Lord's true prophets. In the future, the situation would be reversed.

Zechariah 13:4

ashamed to claim the prophetic gift (literally *ashamed of his vision*): The Old Testament prophet was sometimes identified as a visionary "seer" (see [1 Sam 9:9-19](#); [2 Kgs 17:13](#)), since divine revelation often came to them in dreams or night visions (e.g., [Zech 1:7-6:15](#)). • prophet's clothes: A coarse cloak of camel or goat hair distinctively garbed the Old Testament Hebrew prophets (see [2 Kgs 1:8](#); [Matt 3:4](#)).

Zechariah 13:4-6

God's total cleansing of his people from their impurities will strike such fear among the people that false prophets will deny or conceal their identity, even lying about the nature and purpose of their activities that might be associated with the prophets of idolatrous cults.

Zechariah 13:5

I'm a farmer: This might be a parody of [Amos 7:14](#).

Zechariah 13:6

wounds on your chest?: These wounds might be cuts or bruises that ecstatic prophets, especially in Canaanite religious circles, sometimes gave themselves (see [1 Kgs 18:28](#)). False prophets would make excuses for themselves, such as, I was wounded at my friends' house!

Zechariah 13:7

The sword is personified as a warrior being called to awake in battle, heightening its image as God's servant, an instrument of death (see [Isa 31:8](#); [34:6](#); [66:16](#)). • My shepherd signifies the Messiah, the coming leader of Israel (see [Ezek 34:23](#); [37:24](#)). • My partner conveys the equality of the shepherd with God (see [Matt 26:31](#); [Mark 14:27](#)).

Zechariah 13:7-9

This message describes a coming day when God's appointed shepherd of Israel would be struck down, and the sheep (the people of Israel) would be scattered. A portion of the nation would be given over to divine judgment, while part of the nation would experience spiritual renewal, fulfilling Zechariah's vision of God once again among his people (see [1:16](#); [2:5](#), [10-11](#); [8:3](#), [23](#)). The Gospel writers connect portions of this passage ([13:7](#)) to the scattering of Jesus' disciples as a result of the events surrounding his arrest, trial, and execution by the Romans (see [Matt 26:31](#), [56](#)).

Zechariah 13:8

Two-thirds . . . one-third: The divine judgment would be catastrophic, but God would preserve a remnant and forgive their sin (see [Isa 65:9](#); [Jer 50:20](#); [Ezek 5:2-12](#); [Rev 9:15-18](#)).

Zechariah 13:9

Fire is a metaphor for God's judgment (see [Isa 66:15](#); [Jer 4:4](#); [Ezek 36:5](#); [Amos 5:6](#)). God's *fire* may either destroy the wicked or, as here, test and purify the righteous. • refine them . . . like gold: God is the divine metallurgist, using fire to burn the dross out of metal ([Isa 1:25](#); [Mal 3:2-3](#)). • These are my people . . . The Lord is our God: The declarations of loyalty by God and Israel restore their broken covenant relationship ([Zech 11:10](#), [14](#); see [Exod 19:5](#); [Jer 30:22](#); [31:33](#); [Hos 2:23](#)).

Zechariah 14:1

The day of the Lord will bring judgment and deliverance and will reverse the fortunes of many (see [Amos 5:18](#); cp. [Matt 19:28-30](#); [Luke 13:23-30](#)).

Zechariah 14:1-21

Zechariah closes with visions of judgment, salvation, and God's universal kingdom. In the future, Israel would be besieged, teetering on the verge of total destruction, when the Lord himself would intervene and rescue his people ([14:3-4](#)) and punish their enemies with a terrible plague

([14:12](#)). Israel would be restored as God's people, and Jerusalem would be exalted as the center of civilization ([14:16-17](#)). God's rule would be established over all the earth ([14:9](#)), and the created order would be transformed ([14:6-10](#)). Fittingly, God's holiness would be the pervasive characteristic of his rule over all the earth ([14:20-21](#)). Zechariah's message stimulates the people of God to hope in the Sovereign King of Israel, who will bring justice and restoration.

Zechariah 14:2

The rest is the remnant of Israel that survived the sack of Jerusalem (see [13:8](#)).

Zechariah 14:3

fought in times past: An example would be the exodus from Egypt ([Exod 14-15](#); see [Isa 42:13](#)).

Zechariah 14:4

Jesus ascended into heaven from the Mount of Olives, and the angels' message to Jesus' disciples ([Acts 1:11-12](#)) implied that he would return in a similar fashion. • Zechariah envisions an earthquake that will split apart the Mount of Olives and create a valley running east and west through the fissure. This valley will become an escape route for Hebrews fleeing Jerusalem during the assault by the nations ([Zech 14:5](#)). This event is probably connected to the return of Jesus at the end of the age (see [Matt 24](#); [Rev 6:12](#); [11:13](#); [16:18](#)).

Zechariah 14:5

Some identify Azal (Hebrew 'atsal) as a district on the northeast side of Jerusalem inhabited by descendants of Azel ([1 Chr 8:37-39](#); [9:43-44](#)). Others emend the Hebrew to 'etsel, "alongside" or "the side [of it]." • The date of the earthquake in the days of King Uzziah is unknown, but Amos began his ministry two years before it ([Amos 1:1](#)). • The holy ones are probably the multitude of angels that worship God and serve as his army (see [Ps 89:5](#), [7](#)).

Zechariah 14:7

continuous day: The day of the Lord will bring fundamental changes to the created order (see [Isa 60:19-22](#); [Rev 21:22-25](#)). This promise emphasizes that the sun and moon are created by God and are not eternal deities—light does not originate with them.

Zechariah 14:8

The life-giving waters . . . from Jerusalem symbolize God's life-giving presence among his people (see [Ezek 47:1-12](#); [Joel 3:18](#); [John 7:37-39](#); [Rev 22:1-2](#)). • half toward the Dead Sea and half toward the Mediterranean: Divine blessings will extend both east and west, flowing continuously. They will never stop bringing healing (see [Isa 30:23-26](#)).

Zechariah 14:9

the Lord will be king: Zechariah envisions the ultimate fulfillment of many psalms (see [Pss 47-48, 93, 97-99](#)). • there will be one Lord: This promise reaffirms Israel's creed ([Deut 6:4](#)) and signals a final end of all idolatry.

Zechariah 14:10

The towns Geba and Rimmon represent the north-south extent of the district including Jerusalem.

Zechariah 14:12

As divine Judge, God strikes those who rebel against him with a sudden and deadly plague (see [Exod 9:14](#); [Num 14:36-37](#); [2 Sam 24:10-25](#); [Jer 14:11-12](#)).

Zechariah 14:13

The day of the Lord will bring terror to God's enemies ([12:4](#); see [Isa 22:5](#)).

Zechariah 14:14

The day of the Lord is characterized by reversal: The capture of the wealth of the nations overturns

the looting of Jerusalem announced earlier ([14:1](#)). • great quantities of gold and silver: The Lord's Temple will receive "the treasures of all the nations" ([Hag 2:7-8](#)).

Zechariah 14:16

- *the nations ... will go up ... to worship the King*: Another reversal will happen on the day of the Lord (compare [Philippians 2:8-11](#)).
- The annual Feast of Tabernacles marked the start of the fall harvest season. It commemorated Israel's time in the wilderness after leaving Egypt (see [Exodus 23:14-19](#); [Leviticus 23:33-43](#); [Numbers 29:12-40](#); [Deuteronomy 16:13-17](#)). The festival gave the worshipping community a chance to thank God for his provision. It encouraged social concern for the disadvantaged and reliance on God as pilgrims in this world. Thanksgiving will define worship in the messianic era (see [Isaiah 51:3](#); [Jeremiah 33:11](#)).

Zechariah 14:17

come to Jerusalem to worship: Jerusalem, with God's Temple, is envisioned as the center of God's universal kingdom ([8:20-22](#); see [Isa 56:6-7](#); [66:19-23](#); [Mic 4:1](#); [Hag 2:7](#); [Rev 21:1-2, 10-27](#)). • no rain: This was one of the curses God pronounced against Israel for covenant disobedience (see [Deut 28:22-24](#)). That curse extended to all the nations, as God's rule extends over all peoples (cp. [Zech 10:1](#)).

Zechariah 14:20

Holy to the Lord: See study note on 3:5. The priesthood was set apart for the Lord, as was the nation of Israel ([Exod 19:6](#); [Lev 11:44-45](#)). That identity will be fulfilled in the messianic kingdom ([Rom 11:16-17](#); [Eph 1:4](#); [5:27](#); [1 Pet 1:15-16](#)). The inscription on the harness bells and the cooking pots shows how pervasive holiness will be in that day.

Zechariah 14:21

every cooking pot: The holiness of God's kingdom will transform even mundane utensils into sacred vessels like those used in the sacrificial ritual of the Temple, eliminating all Old Testament distinctions between the sacred and the profane. • traders (literally *Canaanites*): Commercial activity was associated with the Canaanites (see [Hos 12:7](#); [Zeph 1:11](#)). The expression might be a euphemism for idolaters or another way of saying that under God's rule, traditional ethnic boundaries will be dissolved. The passage may anticipate the work of Jesus in cleansing the Jerusalem Temple as a prelude to the greater work of cleansing the heart of those who believe in him by the Holy Spirit (see [John 2:13-16](#); [1 Cor 6:11](#); [Titus 3:5](#)).